

IEP Goal Bank

for Students with DLD

50 Customizable Goals Across 6 Domains

Vocabulary

Grammar & Sentences

Narrative Language

Reading Comprehension

Writing

Executive Function

WHAT'S INCLUDED

- **How to Write IEP Goals guide** - A practical one-page reference for SLPs and educators
- **Goal anatomy formula** - Visual breakdown with a fully worked example
- **6 DLD-specific writing tips** - Evidence-based guidance to strengthen every goal
- **50 fillable IEP goals** - Customizable fields across all six domains
- **Interactive Goal Builder** - Fill in and copy goals at empowereddld.com

How to Write IEP Goals for Students with DLD

A practical guide for SLPs and educators
Empowered DLD · empowereddld.com

Note: These goals are to get you started. Please personalize them for your individual students.

What is DLD?

Developmental Language Disorder (DLD) is a significant, persistent difficulty with language that is not explained by hearing loss, autism, or another known condition. It affects approximately **1 in 14 children** and impacts vocabulary, grammar, reading, writing, and social communication across all settings. Effective, targeted IEP goals are one of the most powerful tools we have to support students with DLD.

The anatomy of a strong IEP goal

By [date]	+	[Student] will...	+	Level of support	+	Accuracy / Criteria	+	How measured
Target date		Observable behaviour		Independent, visual only, # prompts		x/y opportunities across n sessions		Work samples, data, observation

Example goal

By June 2026, Maya will retell a story including key elements (character, setting, problem, solution) with visual supports only in 4 out of 5 opportunities across 3 sessions as measured by clinician observation data.

Tips for writing better goals for students with DLD

Target language, not just behaviour

DLD affects language processing at its core. Goals should address vocabulary, grammar, narrative, reading comprehension, and writing — not just attention or compliance.

Make the support level explicit

Students with DLD often need visual supports, repetition, or graphic organizers. Naming the support in the goal makes it measurable and protects the student's right to it.

Use evidence-based methods

Semantic Feature Analysis (SFA) and story grammar frameworks have strong evidence bases for DLD. Reference these approaches in your goals where possible.

Write goals across all six domains

Students with DLD benefit from goals across vocabulary, grammar, narrative, reading, writing, and executive function — all of these areas are interconnected.

Keep criteria realistic but ambitious

Aim for 80% accuracy across 3 or more sessions to show true generalization. Avoid single-session data as evidence of mastery for students with DLD.

Involve the whole team

Goals written collaboratively between SLPs, educators, and parents are more likely to be carried through consistently. Use shared language across settings.

Use this goal bank alongside the interactive IEP Goal Builder at empowereddld.com — fill in student-specific details online and copy directly into your IEP documents.

Vocabulary

6 goals

1 Use strategies to determine meaning of unfamiliar words

By _____, _____ will use strategies (e.g., context clues, visual supports, looking up definitions/synonyms, asking for clarification) to determine the meaning of unfamiliar words independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) per item when reading/listening to ____ in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

2 Use graphic organizers for Tier 2 vocabulary word relationships

By _____, _____ will use graphic organizers to visually represent word relationships of _ [number] targeted Tier 2 vocabulary words independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) per word across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

3 Describe features of vocabulary using a semantic feature organizer

By _____, _____ will describe at least ____ features of targeted vocabulary using a semantic feature organizer independently or with visual supports only or no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

4 Group vocabulary into categories and explain relationships

By _____, _____ will group vocabulary into categories and explain relationships independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) per task in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

5 Infer word meanings using context clues

By _____, _____ will infer word meanings of at least ____ target words per session using context clues independently or with no more than ____ reminder(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

6 Identify unknown words and use a repair strategy

By _____, _____ will identify when they do not understand a word and use a strategy to repair understanding in ____ instances per session independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

Grammar and Sentence Structure

6 goals

7 Produce sentences with adverbial clauses

By _____, _____ will produce sentences containing adverbial clauses independently or with no more than _____ prompt(s) per sentence in _____ out of _____ opportunities across _____ sessions as measured by _____.

8 Use correct past tense verb forms

By _____, _____ will use correct past tense verb forms independently or with visual supports only or no more than _____ prompt(s) in _____ out of _____ opportunities across _____ sessions as measured by _____.

9 Combine sentences using conjunctions

By _____, _____ will combine sentences using conjunctions in _____ instances per session independently or with no more than _____ prompt(s) across _____ sessions as measured by _____.

10 Combine simple sentences into complex sentences

By _____, _____ will combine simple sentences into more complex sentences independently or with no more than _____ prompt(s) in _____ out of _____ opportunities across _____ sessions as measured by _____.

11 Expand utterances with prepositional phrases, adjectives, or adverbs

By _____, _____ will expand utterances by including _____ [prepositional phrases/ _ adjectives/adverbs etc] in spoken or written sentences independently or with no more than _____ prompt(s) in _____ out of _____ opportunities across _____ sessions as measured by _____.

12 Use comparatives and superlatives accurately

By _____, _____ will use comparatives and superlatives accurately when producing complete sentences independently or with no more than _____ reminder(s) per task in _____ out of _____ opportunities across _____ sessions as measured by _____.

Narrative Language

6 goals

13 Retell a story with key elements

By _____, _____ will retell a story including key elements (character, setting, problem, solution) independently or with visual supports only or no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

14 Sequence events using temporal language

By _____, _____ will sequence events using temporal language in ____ instances per session independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

15 Identify and explain problem and solution using a graphic organizer

By _____, _____ will identify and explain the problem and solution using a graphic organizer independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

16 Generate a story with required story elements

By _____, _____ will generate a story including at least ____ story elements when provided with a graphic organizer independently or with visual supports only or no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

17 Identify characters' thoughts and feelings using text evidence

By _____, _____ will identify characters' thoughts and feelings using cues from the text as supporting evidence independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

18 Use causal and temporal language (because, so, then)

By _____, _____ will use causal and temporal language (because, so, then) at least ____ times per session/when writing sentences independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

Reading Comprehension

6 goals

19 Use comprehension strategies during structured reading tasks

By _____, _____ will use comprehension strategies (predicting, questioning, summarizing) during structured reading tasks independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

20 Answer factual comprehension questions correctly

By _____, _____ will answer factual comprehension questions correctly in ____ out of ____ opportunities independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) per question set when engaged in _____ across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

21 Answer inference questions using text evidence

By _____, _____ will answer inference questions using text evidence independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

22 Identify main idea and supporting details

By _____, _____ will identify the main idea and supporting details independently or with visual supports only and/or no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

23 Identify when text does not make sense and use a repair strategy

By _____, _____ will identify when a text does not make sense and use a strategy in ____ instances per session independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

24 Summarize a passage using a structured framework

By _____, _____ will summarize a passage using a structured framework and a graphic organizer independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

Writing

6 goals

25 Use a graphic organizer to plan writing

By _____, _____ will use a graphic organizer to plan writing independently or with visual supports only or no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

26 Write a paragraph with topic sentence and supporting details

By _____, _____ will use a step-by-step written plan to write a paragraph including a topic sentence and at least ____ supporting details independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

27 Combine sentences to improve complexity

By _____, _____ will combine sentences to improve complexity in ____ instances per task independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

28 Revise written work using a checklist

By _____, _____ will revise written work using a checklist independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

29 Use transition words in writing tasks

By _____, _____ will use transition words at least ____ times per writing task independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

30 Use self-monitoring strategies in writing

By _____, _____ will use self-monitoring strategies (e.g., re-reading, checking clarity) independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

Executive Function

20 goals

Planning and Organization

31 Use a checklist or plan to organize tasks

By _____, _____ will use a checklist or plan to organize tasks independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

32 Break down tasks into smaller steps

By _____, _____ will break down tasks into smaller steps independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

33 Organize ideas using a graphic organizer

By _____, _____ will organize ideas using a graphic organizer including all required components independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

34 Gather materials needed for tasks

By _____, _____ will gather materials needed for tasks independently or with no more than ____ reminder(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

Working Memory

35 Use visuals and checklists to follow multi-step directions

By _____, _____ will use strategies such as visuals, checklists etc to follow multi-step directions independently or with no more than ____ repetition(s) or prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

36 Use memory strategies (repeating, visualizing)

By _____, _____ will use memory strategies (e.g., repeating, visualizing) independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

37 Use strategies to complete tasks requiring recall

By _____, _____ will use strategies such as _____ to complete tasks requiring recall of information independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

Self-Monitoring**38 Identify when they do not understand**

By _____, _____ will identify when they do not understand _____ in ____ instances per session independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

39 Use self-monitoring strategies

By _____, _____ will use self-monitoring strategies and will be rated as _____ independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

40 Use a checklist to accurately review work

By _____, _____ will use a checklist to accurately review work independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

41 Identify one strength and one area for improvement

By _____, _____ will identify one strength and one area for improvement independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

Cognitive Flexibility

42 Generate multiple solutions to a problem

By _____, _____ will generate at least ____ solutions to a problem independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

43 Adjust strategies when needed

By _____, _____ will adjust strategies when needed in ____ instances per session independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

44 Use alternative strategies when tasks are challenging

By _____, _____ will use alternative strategies when tasks are challenging independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

Attention and Persistence**45 Demonstrate goal-directed persistence**

By _____, _____ will demonstrate goal-directed persistence by continuing on when a task is challenging rather than giving up independently or with no more than ____ redirection(s) when engaged in structured language activities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

46 Return to a task after distraction

By _____, _____ will return to a task after distraction independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

47 Complete all steps of a task without skipping

By _____, _____ will complete all steps of a task without skipping steps independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

Initiation and Self-Advocacy

48 Initiate tasks or request appropriate support

By _____, _____ will initiate tasks by starting independently or requesting an appropriate support (e.g. sentence stem, graphic organizer etc) within ____ seconds/minutes independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

49 Self-advocate by sharing needs with a classmate or peer

By _____, _____ will self-advocate by sharing what they need with a classmate or peer (e.g. repetition, a visual support etc) independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) in ____ out of ____ opportunities across ____ sessions as measured by _____.

50 Seek clarification by asking for rephrasing or other support

By _____, _____ will seek clarification by asking an adult/peer to rephrase the information or provide other forms of clarification in ____ instances per session independently or with no more than ____ prompt(s) across ____ sessions as measured by _____.